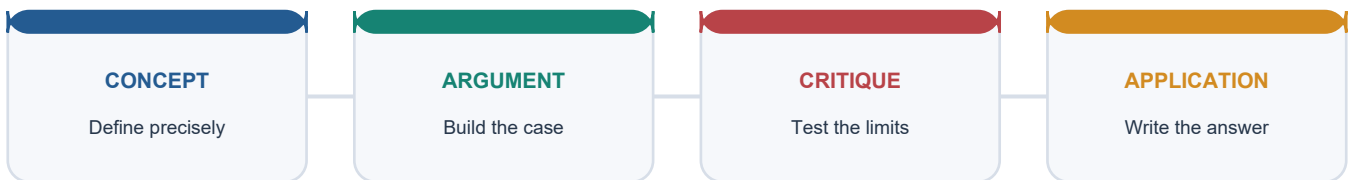


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

The Aryan Problem and Identity of Aryan Culture: Solved Practice Workbook

Solved Practice Workbook

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Solved Practice Workbook Contents

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Aryan Problem and Identity of Aryan Culture: Solved Practice Workbook

Exact practice contract: 32 original hard MCQs appear before PYQs; keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times; 128 option explanations and 32 traps are unique. Direct PYQ ownership is audited honestly, adjacent routes retain key-status discipline, and six original Mains models are independently word-counted.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D, repeated eight times. All 128 option explanations and 32 traps are question-specific.

Q1

1 Which formulation is methodologically safest?

- A. Arya is contextual, while Indo-Aryan is a linguistic category.
- B. Aryan denotes a biological race visible in skeletons.
- C. Indo-Aryan denotes one pottery assemblage.
- D. Arya denotes every Indo-European speaker.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: it preserves the distinction between textual self-designation and linguistic classification. [Q1-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Race cannot be read from the word *arya*. [Q1-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Language does not equal pottery. [Q1-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: The textual term is narrower than the whole language family. [Q1-D]

Examiner trap 1: Separate textual identity from language and biology.

Q2

2 In Rigvedic usage, *arya* is best understood as

- A. a fixed skin-colour category
- B. a contextual insider or status designation
- C. the name of a single archaeological culture
- D. a genetic ancestry component

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The texts do not supply a stable phenotype definition. [Q2-A]
- **B:** Correct: usage varies by passage, alliance and ritual-political context. [Q2-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Archaeological cultures are modern analytical groupings. [Q2-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Genetic components are statistical and modern analytical labels. [Q2-D]

Examiner trap 2: Read *arya* by context, not as a timeless race.

Q3

3 Which colonial-era move created the central racial distortion?

- A. Treating the whole Rigvedic corpus as a late and internally uniform composition

- B. Rejecting every comparison with Avestan
- C. Converting linguistic relationship into biological hierarchy
- D. Dating PGW before the Mature Harappan phase

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Textual dating debate is not the defining racial conversion. [Q3-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Avestan comparison was central to philology. [Q3-B]
- **C:** Correct: speech history was transformed into a superior racial type. [Q3-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: The chronology is wrong but is not the core historiographical move. [Q3-D]

Examiner trap 3: The valid linguistic discovery must be separated from racial typology.

Q4

4 Comparative linguistics establishes Indo-European relationship chiefly through

- A. a small cluster of similar divine names and isolated lexical resemblances across texts
- B. modern national boundaries
- C. a shared pottery style
- D. regular sound correspondences, grammar and inherited vocabulary

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: A single resemblance may be accidental or borrowed. [Q4-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Modern borders are irrelevant to prehistoric language descent. [Q4-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Material style cannot demonstrate phonological descent. [Q4-C]
- **D:** Correct: repeated structural correspondences support genealogical relationship. [Q4-D]

Examiner trap 4: Patterns, not isolated word resemblance, establish language descent.

Q5

5 Vedic Sanskrit belongs to which nested sequence?

- A. Indo-Aryan -> Indo-Iranian -> Indo-European
- B. Iranian -> Indo-Aryan -> Indo-European, treating Iranian as the parent branch
- C. Indo-European -> Dravidian -> Indo-Aryan
- D. BMAC -> Indo-Iranian -> Vedic Sanskrit

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: this is the accepted linguistic hierarchy. [Q5-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Iranian and Indo-Aryan are sister developments, not parent and child. [Q5-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Dravidian is a distinct language family. [Q5-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: BMAC is archaeological, not a linguistic parent. [Q5-D]

Examiner trap 5: Keep linguistic branches separate from archaeological complexes.

Q6

6 The Mitanni evidence most securely demonstrates

- A. that the Rig Veda was composed in Syria
- B. restricted Indo-Aryan forms outside South Asia by the mid-second millennium BCE

- C. that all Mitanni people spoke Vedic Sanskrit
- D. a direct military migration from Mitanni to Punjab

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: External attestation does not locate Rigvedic composition. [Q6-A]
- **B:** Correct: treaty names and technical vocabulary provide bounded external attestation. [Q6-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Hurrian was the majority language. [Q6-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: No direct route or military event follows from the texts. [Q6-D]

Examiner trap 6: Mitanni adds chronology, not a complete route.

Q7

7 Which evidence-class pairing is correct?

- A. Genetics - spoken language of a sampled person
- B. Archaeology - self-declared ethnicity without inscriptions
- C. Comparative linguistics - language descent and contact
- D. Rigvedic poetry - exact census data

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: DNA does not record language. [Q7-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Objects do not self-identify ethnicity. [Q7-B]
- **C:** Correct: sound, grammar and vocabulary establish relationship and borrowing. [Q7-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Ritual poetry is not a statistical census. [Q7-D]

Examiner trap 7: Each evidence class has a different object.

Q8

8 Before combining two datasets, the first requirement is to

- A. assume they describe one people
- B. prefer the newest discipline and let it automatically override all earlier evidence classes
- C. discard contradictory results
- D. match chronology, geography, scale and independence

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Shared labels cannot substitute for proof. [Q8-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Novelty does not determine evidentiary weight. [Q8-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Contradictions must be preserved and explained. [Q8-C]
- **D:** Correct: convergence is meaningful only after these controls. [Q8-D]

Examiner trap 8: Triangulation begins with compatibility, not fusion.

Q9

9 The Rig Veda is most accurately described as

- A. a layered ritual-poetic corpus with historical clues
- B. a securely dated royal chronicle recording successive rulers, battles and migrations
- C. an archaeological field report

- D. a complete census of early society

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: genre, oral transmission and layering define its use. [Q9-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: It has no annalistic year-by-year structure. [Q9-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Material context must come from archaeology. [Q9-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Elite ritual poetry cannot enumerate the whole population. [Q9-D]

Examiner trap 9: Use the Rig Veda intensively but not literally.

Q10

10 Which statement about Sarasvati/Ghaggar-Hakra is best?

- A. Their identity proves Harappan language.
- B. Palaeochannel, occupation and textual chronology must be tested separately.
- C. a similar river name fixes a single migration route and synchronises Vedic and Harappan dates
- D. Every Harappan site belonged to one river system.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The Harappan script remains undeciphered. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Correct: hydrology, archaeology and textual layering are independent controls. [Q10-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: A hydronym cannot establish one migration itinerary. [Q10-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Harappan sites occupied several ecological zones. [Q10-D]

Examiner trap 10: A palaeochannel is not automatically a named Vedic river.

Q11

11 Rigvedic economic vocabulary supports

- A. exclusive urban commerce
- B. complete nomadism without cultivation
- C. pastoral predominance within an agro-pastoral economy
- D. an iron-centred agrarian state

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The corpus does not depict Harappan-style urbanism. [Q11-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Ploughing, wells and harvest vocabulary contradict exclusive nomadism. [Q11-B]
- **C:** Correct: cattle-centred values coexist with cultivation and craft. [Q11-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Early *ayas* should not be converted automatically into iron. [Q11-D]

Examiner trap 11: Pastoral emphasis and agriculture can coexist.

Q12

12 In an early Rigvedic context, *ayas* should

- A. always be translated as iron and used to assign every hymn to an iron-using agrarian society
- B. be ignored because texts are oral
- C. prove PGW identity
- D. be treated cautiously, often within a copper/bronze material world

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Iron-centred development is later and regionally variable. [Q12-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Oral texts remain valuable with source criticism. [Q12-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: A word cannot identify a pottery assemblage. [Q12-C]
- **D:** Correct: translation depends on context and chronology. [Q12-D]

Examiner trap 12: Do not back-project later iron into every early reference.

Q13

13 Which sequence correctly handles horse/chariot evidence?

- A. species -> context -> frequency/use -> vehicle form -> chronology
- B. horse terminology and ritual prominence directly prove one invasion and its military mechanism
- C. solid wheel -> light spoked chariot
- D. equid fragment -> ethnic identity

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: every inferential step must be demonstrated. [Q13-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Textual importance does not prove a military event. [Q13-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Wheel construction is a decisive distinction. [Q13-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Animal identification cannot establish ethnicity. [Q13-D]

Examiner trap 13: Presence, centrality and technology are separate claims.

Q14

14 Surkotada is used cautiously because

- A. it has a deciphered horse inscription
- B. equid species identification and wider significance remain debated
- C. it contains a secure Sintashta chariot
- D. it proves horses were absent throughout South Asia before later second-millennium movements

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: No deciphered Harappan inscription supplies that label. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Correct: morphology, context and representativeness remain disputed. [Q14-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Sintashta is a separate steppe context. [Q14-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: A disputed find cannot prove universal absence. [Q14-D]

Examiner trap 14: A debated equid is neither proof of centrality nor proof of absence.

Q15

15 Sintashta-Petrovka is important chiefly for

- A. a Harappan urban script
- B. solid-wheel carts in the upper Ganga plain that securely identify early Vedic-speaking migrants
- C. early second-millennium spoked-wheel vehicle contexts
- D. a direct Rigvedic manuscript

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: It is not Harappan. [Q15-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: That description fits neither location nor vehicle evidence. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Correct: chariot technology and metallurgy make it a key comparative horizon. [Q15-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: No Rigvedic manuscript comes from the site. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: Technology strengthens a model but does not itself identify language.

Q16

16 The safest statement about Sanauli is that

- A. horse sacrifice is proven
- B. the burials are securely Vedic
- C. the vehicles are Sintashta-type spoked chariots
- D. two-wheeled solid-wheel vehicles occur; draught animal and identity remain unsettled

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: No horse remains securely establish the claim. [Q16-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Burial identity cannot be read directly. [Q16-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: The vehicles have solid rather than demonstrated spoked wheels. [Q16-C]
- **D:** Correct: this distinguishes observation from interpretation. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: Media use of "chariot" must not erase wheel and draught evidence.

Q17

17 Which statement best fits Harappan decline?

- A. It was a regionally varied transformation with no civilisation-wide invasion horizon.
- B. It occurred through one massacre at Mohenjo-daro.
- C. It proves no later movement into South Asia.
- D. It was simultaneous at every site.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: urban contraction, localisation and continuity varied regionally. [Q17-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: The skeletons do not form one massacre context. [Q17-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Rejection of invasion does not prove zero migration. [Q17-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Site chronologies differ. [Q17-D]

Examiner trap 17: Do not use Harappan decline as a shortcut verdict on later migration.

Q18

18 Cemetery H most usefully demonstrates

- A. a named Indo-Aryan tribe whose language and migration route can be read directly from its burials
- B. continuity with mortuary and material change
- C. a complete population replacement
- D. the language of Harappa

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Burial assemblages do not provide a self-name. [Q18-A]
- **B:** Correct: continuity and changed urn practices must be assessed together. [Q18-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: The record does not show total replacement. [Q18-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Harappan writing remains undeciphered. [Q18-D]

Examiner trap 18: Mortuary change is not an ethnic label.

Q19

19 The Gandhara Grave/Swat evidence should be treated as

- A. one brief invasion event
- B. a uniform race marker
- C. a long, varied frontier interaction sequence
- D. a direct translation of Rigvedic burial rules

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Its broad chronology contradicts a single event. [Q19-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Burial practices do not define race. [Q19-B]
- **C:** Correct: varied rites and contacts make corridor analysis safer. [Q19-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Text and graves cannot be equated automatically. [Q19-D]

Examiner trap 19: Chronological breadth defeats a one-wave interpretation.

Q20

20 OCP and copper hoards cannot be equated with Aryans mainly because

- A. copper was unknown in South Asia
- B. OCP occurs only in Central Asia
- C. all copper hoards are ritual deposits of one incoming community, irrespective of find context
- D. associations and contexts vary, while objects do not identify language

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Copper use is well attested. [Q20-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: OCP is associated with the upper Ganga-Yamuna region. [Q20-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Functions vary and many finds lack context. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Correct: heterogeneous context blocks an ethnic equation. [Q20-D]

Examiner trap 20: An antennae sword is not a linguistic fossil.

Q21

21 Painted Grey Ware is best used as

- A. a later Vedic/early Iron Age archaeological comparison with regional limits
- B. the unique pottery of early Rigvedic migrants, allowing its distribution to map language spread
- C. proof that every PGW site used iron
- D. a Mature Harappan urban marker

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: its chronology and geography fit later transformations better. [Q21-A]

- **B:** Incorrect: PGW cannot identify speakers and is generally later. [Q21-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Some PGW contexts lack iron. [Q21-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: It post-dates Mature Harappan urbanism. [Q21-D]

Examiner trap 21: PGW is a correlate, not "the Aryans".

Q22

22 BMAC is best understood as

- A. a single Indo-Iranian nation
- B. an oasis interaction world linked with mobile groups
- C. a Harappan colony
- D. a genetic ancestry component

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Archaeology cannot supply that national-language identity. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Correct: settlement, craft and ritual networks interacted with steppe groups. [Q22-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: No evidence supports simple colonial identity. [Q22-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: BMAC names an archaeological complex, not DNA. [Q22-D]

Examiner trap 22: Use BMAC as a network node, not a conveyor belt.

Q23

23 Why can archaeology not identify Vedic Sanskrit speakers by itself?

- A. Sites have no chronology.
- B. Pottery cannot be classified.
- C. Material assemblages spread by varied mechanisms and do not directly record speech.
- D. texts are always more accurate than objects and can assign speech to any contemporary assemblage

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Archaeological chronology is often strong. [Q23-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Classification is possible but remains analytical. [Q23-B]
- **C:** Correct: trade, imitation, marriage and mobility break one-to-one mapping. [Q23-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Texts and objects answer different questions; neither is automatically superior. [Q23-D]

Examiner trap 23: An assemblage is not a language community.

Q24

24 A migration model differs from an invasion model because migration

- A. excludes conflict
- B. requires no movement
- C. always means elite dominance by male warrior bands and excludes household or pastoral mobility
- D. can be gradual, multi-phase and compatible with local continuity

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Conflict may occur without defining the whole process. [Q24-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Migration necessarily involves mobility. [Q24-B]

- **C:** Incorrect: Several social mechanisms are possible. [Q24-C]
- **D:** Correct: movement need not be conquest or replacement. [Q24-D]

Examiner trap 24: Do not make invasion and migration synonyms.

Q25

25 A rigorous indigenous/Out-of-India model must explain

- A. Indo-European branching, Indo-Iranian innovations, Mitanni and later ancestry evidence
- B. only Sarasvati identification, because one river match would settle homeland and chronology
- C. only cultural continuity
- D. only the absence of a massacre horizon

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: a full model must address all contrary evidence classes. [Q25-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: One river claim cannot settle the family history. [Q25-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Continuity does not determine language origin. [Q25-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: No massacre excludes mass invasion, not all mobility. [Q25-D]

Examiner trap 25: A model is tested by the evidence it can explain, not by one favoured fact.

Q26

26 Ancient DNA can directly establish

- A. the language spoken by a skeleton when its ancestry matches a historically attested population
- B. ancestry relationships in a dated sampled individual
- C. the caste of a Bronze Age community
- D. the religious identity of a burial

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Language is not encoded in DNA. [Q26-A]
- **B:** Correct: this is the method's proper object. [Q26-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Caste is historical and cannot be read directly from one genome. [Q26-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Burial meaning needs cultural evidence. [Q26-D]

Examiner trap 26: Ancestry is biological evidence with sample limits.

Q27

27 The strongest safe conclusion from the published Rakhigarhi genome is

- A. all Harappans lacked Steppe ancestry
- B. Harappans spoke a non-Indo-European language
- C. one sampled Mature Harappan lacked detectable Steppe-pastoralist ancestry
- D. no later Steppe-related movement occurred

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: One person cannot represent all Harappans. [Q27-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Language was not recovered. [Q27-B]
- **C:** Correct: the claim is bounded by person, context and date. [Q27-C]

- **D:** Incorrect: Later movement is a different chronological question. [Q27-D]

Examiner trap 27: Always state "one published individual".

Q28

28 Narasimhan et al. 2019 is most accurately used to support

- A. a pure Aryan race
- B. one exact invasion date and route derived from modelled admixture estimates across all regions
- C. the language of every sampled individual
- D. later Steppe-related movement plus extensive IVC-related continuity and mixture

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The study rejects pure-race framing. [Q28-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Admixture is modelled over ranges. [Q28-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Genomes do not speak. [Q28-C]
- **D:** Correct: the regional dataset supports movement and mixture together. [Q28-D]

Examiner trap 28: The study models population history, not an Aryan gene.

Q29

29 Absence of archaeological evidence is strongest when

- A. preservation, survey coverage and expected visibility are considered
- B. nothing has yet been excavated
- C. a text predicts an event
- D. one excavated site lacks an artefact expected from a text, regardless of regional preservation

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: patterned absence requires an expectation of survival and discovery. [Q29-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Unsearched ground makes absence weak. [Q29-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Textual expectation does not create material evidence. [Q29-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: One local absence rarely supports a regional universal. [Q29-D]

Examiner trap 29: Absence is evidence only after a visibility test.

Q30

30 Which process best explains early Vedic identity formation?

- A. complete replacement of local populations
- B. mobility combined with bilingualism, alliance, intermarriage and borrowing
- C. unchanged preservation of a sealed migrant culture without borrowing, intermarriage or adaptation
- D. one royal decree imposing language

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The evidence supports substantial local continuity. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Correct: several social mechanisms can spread language and practices. [Q30-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Contact features contradict sealed preservation. [Q30-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: No such decree is known. [Q30-D]

Examiner trap 30: Identity formed through interaction, not purity.

Q31

31 Which three-level conclusion is best?

- A. Every issue is unresolved.
- B. all linguistic, archaeological, textual and genetic evidence proves the same migration event
- C. Secure linguistic relationship; probable multi-phase movement; exact route and scale unresolved.
- D. One archaeological culture settles the debate.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Several conclusions are high-confidence. [Q31-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Evidence classes have different objects. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Correct: this grades facts, interpretations and open questions. [Q31-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: No assemblage has that power. [Q31-D]

Examiner trap 31: Neutrality ranks evidence rather than flattening it.

Q32

32 Which answer sequence is most defensible?

- A. Genetics -> race -> ownership claim
- B. Sarasvati -> Harappan language -> final verdict
- C. Horse bone -> invasion -> replacement
- D. define categories -> order chronology -> triangulate -> compare models -> qualify

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: This commits category and presentist errors. [Q32-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: River identification cannot decipher language. [Q32-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: One faunal item cannot prove a military demographic event. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Correct: this sequence makes the reasoning auditable. [Q32-D]

Examiner trap 32: A source-critical answer is an argument, not a slogan or catalogue.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AND KEY DISCIPLINE

Direct ownership audit: the repository's verified 2018-2026 routing ledgers contain **zero direct Aryan-origin or migration PYQs** for Topic 07. No question is relabelled to manufacture ownership.

Adjacent verified route	Status	Correct Topic 07 use
2026 Prelims Set A Q10 - Rigvedic irrigation, wells and draught power	Question verified; local key provisional, so no official answer letter claimed	Tests bounded material vocabulary, not migration
2026 Prelims Set A Q15 - Vedic river names	Question verified; local key provisional	Tests precise textual geography, not an ethnic map
2026 Prelims Set A Q20 - <i>Kshetra-patni</i>	Question verified; local key provisional	Tests vocabulary; no full cultural chronology follows

Adjacent verified route	Status	Correct Topic 07 use
2023 GS-I Q11 - Vedic society, religion and persistence	Exact Mains question verified; UPSC publishes no official model answer	Cultural-profile route owned primarily by Topic 08
2024 GS-I Q1 - Rig-to-Later Vedic society and economy	Exact Mains question verified; UPSC publishes no official model answer	Transition route owned primarily by Topics 08-09

Key discipline: official wording and official answer keys are distinct. The three 2026 objective questions retain provisional-key status; no official option is asserted here. The two descriptive questions have instructional answer routes, never an "official model answer."

Adjacent Mains route - 2023 GS-I Q11

Verified wording: What are the main features of Vedic society and religion? Do you think some of the features are still prevailing in Indian society? (250 words, 15 marks.)

Topic 07 answer route: define the layered textual source; identify kinship, chiefly authority, pastoral-agricultural life, sacrifice and major deities; separate early from later Vedic traits; discuss only carefully qualified continuities. Do not convert the question into an Aryan-origin verdict.

Adjacent Mains route - 2024 GS-I Q1

Verified wording: Underline the changes in the field of society and economy from the Rig Vedic to the later Vedic period. (150 words, 10 marks.)

Topic 07 answer route: compare cattle-centred agro-pastoral life with more settled agrarian production, kin-based groups with territorial tendencies and fluid hierarchy with later hardening. Use PGW only as a qualified archaeological context, not as the ethnicity of Vedic speakers.

SIX ORIGINAL MAINS QUESTIONS WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Why must *arya*, Indo-Aryan language and biological ancestry be kept analytically separate? (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (125 words):

The three terms answer different questions. In the Rig Veda, *arya* is a contextual self-designation linked to alliance, status and ritual-political belonging. Indo-Aryan is a linguistic subgroup established through regular correspondences with Iranian and wider Indo-European languages. Biological ancestry is reconstructed statistically from sampled genomes. None automatically identifies the others. Thus a PGW vessel cannot be called Indo-Aryan merely from its style, and one Rakhigarhi genome cannot establish Harappan language. The distinction also corrects colonial race theory, which converted linguistic kinship into biological hierarchy. A sound reconstruction may correlate language history, archaeological context and ancestry movement, but it must state the independent evidence and limit at every step. The category firewall does not deny mobility; it prevents mobility from becoming a racial or civilisational essence.

Demand decoding: Define the three categories, show one false equation and end with the methodological gain.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The answer directly distinguishes textual, linguistic and genetic evidence, uses PGW and Rakhigarhi, and qualifies convergence.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Assess the value and limits of the Rig Veda for the Aryan problem. (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (124 words):

The Rig Veda is indispensable for early Indo-Aryan language, ritual vocabulary, cattle-centred values, horse-chariot imagery and a broad north-western river world. Its family books help locate an early textual horizon around the Sindhu and its tributaries. Yet the corpus is orally transmitted, layered and ritual-poetic, not a dated migration chronicle or census. A hymn may combine memory, praise, myth and polemic; textual prominence cannot be converted into material frequency. The text also cannot identify the language of Cemetery H, PGW or another archaeological assemblage. Its evidence becomes strongest when clusters of references are compared with external linguistic chronology and independently dated archaeology. The Rig Veda therefore reconstructs a cultural world with exceptional richness, but not an exact route, population count or one-to-one ethnic map.

Demand decoding: Balance value and limitation; include genre, layering, geography and the archaeology boundary.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The model answers "assess", uses named textual features and prevents literalist or dismissive extremes.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Why is migration-and-interaction a better framework than a simple Aryan invasion model? Discuss. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (180 words):

A simple invasion model implies sudden conquest, a broad destruction horizon and substantial replacement. That model does not fit the archaeological record. Harappan cities declined unevenly, the Mohenjo-daro skeletons do not represent one massacre, and Late Harappan regional cultures preserve population and material continuities. This evidence rejects a civilisational destruction story, but not all later mobility.

Comparative linguistics securely places Vedic Sanskrit within Indo-Iranian and Indo-European. Mitanni divine names and horse-training vocabulary provide external Indo-Aryan attestation by the mid-second millennium BCE. BMAC, Sintashta and Swat show interaction corridors and technologies, although no assemblage identifies a language by itself. The 2019 Rakhigarhi genome constrains one Mature Harappan individual, while Narasimhan et al.'s wider dataset supports later Steppe-related ancestry movement alongside extensive IVC-related continuity.

Migration-and-interaction can combine these findings through repeated small movements, pastoral and elite networks, bilingualism, marriage, conflict and borrowing. It explains language spread without requiring an invading race or disappearance of local populations. Exact routes, scale, gender balance and political mechanisms remain debated. The strongest conclusion is therefore mobility plus acculturation and regional synthesis, not invasion or purity.

Demand decoding: Contrast model predictions, test them against archaeology, linguistics and aDNA, then name social mechanisms.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The model uses four independent evidence classes and clearly distinguishes rejection of invasion from rejection of migration.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Can Cemetery H, Gandhara Grave, OCP or PGW identify the speakers of Vedic Sanskrit? Discuss. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (189 words):

Archaeological cultures classify recurring combinations of pottery, burial, house form, tools and diet. They provide chronology and material context, but they do not record speech or self-identified ethnicity unless independent inscriptions or texts exist.

Cemetery H combines Harappan pottery continuity with changed mortuary practices; this indicates transformation, not a named migrant people. Gandhara Grave or Swat spans a long period with varied burials and outside contacts, making a single-wave label untenable. OCP overlaps Late Harappan contexts at some sites, while many copper hoards lack secure stratigraphy. PGW is mainly a later Vedic and early Iron Age comparison; it overlaps Late Harappan material at some settlements but follows it after a break elsewhere.

These horizons can be correlated with textual and linguistic developments only cautiously. Objects may spread through trade, imitation, marriage, specialist mobility or demographic movement, and one language can cross several assemblages. Bhagwanpura is therefore evidence of sequence and interaction, not a bilingual name-tag. Archaeology is indispensable to reconstruct the setting of Vedic cultural formation, but none of these cultures can independently identify Vedic Sanskrit speakers. The correct vocabulary is "associated with", "overlaps with" and "may reflect contact".

Demand decoding: Define archaeological culture, compare all four horizons and finish with a controlled vocabulary.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The model gives each named culture a distinct evidentiary role and explicitly answers the identity question.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Evaluate the contribution and limits of ancient DNA to the Aryan problem. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (202 words):

Ancient DNA has added direct biological evidence to a debate long dominated by text, language and archaeology. It can identify ancestry affinities and admixture in dated sampled individuals, test whether population movement is plausible and compare regions across time.

Shinde et al.'s 2019 *Cell* study recovered one Mature Harappan genome from Rakhigarhi. That individual lacked detectable Steppe-pastoralist ancestry; the result is a significant chronological constraint, not proof about every Harappan or the language of the civilisation. Its Iranian-related component represented a deep lineage rather than a simple recent migration of sampled western farmers.

Narasimhan et al.'s 2019 *Science* study analysed 523 ancient individuals from Central and northern South Asia. It supports later Steppe-related ancestry movement and extensive IVC-related contribution to later South Asian populations. This pattern is consistent with migration and mixture rather than either mass replacement or complete isolation.

Limits remain decisive: preservation and contamination, uneven geographic sampling, cemetery selection, small regional samples, sex bias, reference-population choice and modelled admixture ranges. An ancestry component is not a language, race, caste, religion or self-identity. Genetics is therefore strongest when triangulated with Indo-Iranian linguistics, Mitanni chronology and archaeological contexts. It changes probabilities and chronology; it cannot independently pronounce who was "Aryan".

Demand decoding: Explain method, treat Rakhigarhi and the wider study separately, list sample/model limits, then restore triangulation.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The answer uses dated peer-reviewed studies, exact sample scope and explicit language-culture limits.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Examine the political misuse of the Aryan question and propose a neutral source-criticism framework. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (210 words):

The Aryan question has repeatedly been converted from historical inquiry into a claim about hierarchy or ownership. Colonial philology correctly recognised language relationship but often racialised it, presenting a superior Aryan people as the maker of civilisation. Later nationalist and communal arguments sometimes reversed the conclusion while retaining the same essentialist method: an ancient word, pot, river or genome becomes a certificate of modern purity.

A neutral framework begins with a category firewall. *Arya* is a contextual textual designation; Indo-Aryan is linguistic; archaeological culture records material practice; ancient DNA records sampled ancestry. It then orders chronology: Mature Harappan urbanism largely precedes the conventional Rigvedic horizon, while post-Harappan cultures and Central Asian corridors overlap unevenly.

Each evidence class receives a bounded task. Comparative linguistics establishes descent and contact; Mitanni supplies external attestation; the Rig Veda supplies a layered north-western textual world; archaeology tests material sequence; Rakhigarhi and Narasimhan et al. constrain population history. Competing models are evaluated against all classes. The mass-invasion model fails; complete zero-mobility faces substantial contrary evidence; multi-phase migration and interaction best fit the current record.

Neutrality does not mean equal weight for every claim. It means distinguishing secure facts, probable synthesis and unresolved route, scale, language and identity. Ancient mobility or continuity cannot confer modern political legitimacy.

Demand decoding: Trace misuse, establish the firewall, weigh evidence by function and end with graded confidence.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Each body paragraph links a named source or case to its precise inference and then states the category, chronology or sampling limit.

Why this earns marks: The model combines historiography, method and a clear verdict without turning uncertainty into false equivalence.